



Beex

EST 2022



THE
COMPANY

inholland

International Boardroom – UoS3

Export Plan Report 2022 - 2023

(Resit)

Angeline Chatelain	682447
Jessica Redondo Müller	683501
Karla Ostojic	689192
Merel Zwart	655564
Omar Abdulghani	628674

Class: ICB2A

Coach: Wouter Koster

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1. Introduction

1.1. Client

BEEEX Branding is a boutique full-service marketing and PR agency based in Amsterdam, Netherlands. BEEEX focuses on providing both B2C but also B2B services in the fields of social media, public relations, branding design and digital marketing while standing out as a company through their small, young, creative team, that consists of 8 women and offers a personal touch as well as one on one, down to earth cooperation's.

Beex is currently a small business that wishes to remain so. Because they rely heavily on trust and close relationships with their clients, they must be able to communicate effectively.

Importing their company abroad is thus not a priority; however, they would like to open a second office in The Netherlands (Personal communication BEEEX, 2022).

Because the company works with many brands abroad, it would be interesting to export their company abroad in order to gain more connections, opportunities, and thus clients. Indeed, Beex primarily works with European brands. Furthermore, as a small business that wishes to remain small, it is preferable for them to remain in a close and accessible area (BEEEX, 2022; Personal communication BEEEX, 2022).

1.2. Assignment

This task entails developing a strategic plan for the company Beex's international expansion. They expect to learn about the advantages, opportunities, downsides, and threats of exporting their company abroad by including the market of the country in question, cultural aspects, and even marketing aspects.

2. Problem Statement and Analysis

2.1. Outcomes of the client's pitch

Beex, among teachers of the InHolland University of Applied sciences were presented with the chosen export country by our team Xport on the 2nd of November 2022. Our presentation consisted of an introduction to the team and mission, a SWOT analysis of Beex, listing the selection criteria we used, the various candidate countries while indicating why they were chosen and why they were not, based on desk research. Furthermore, we listed the supported justifications for selecting Belgium as export destination in terms of location, language, quality of life, competition, and the PR and social media industries' growth. Bieke van Orten, the CEO of the company, expressed her approval of our selection. Some of the feedback we have received was that the client is curious to learn more about potential new clients in Belgium, any potential drawbacks of exporting, and which specific city in Belgium is best for exporting. Concluding that a more in-depth investigation is outstanding.

2.2. Research questions

The aim of this export plan is to create a detailed full export strategy that will allow BEEEX to safely export their company to Belgium. Therefore, to be able to present a fully substantiated strategy, research questions have been drawn up to support this decision and fully substantiate our choice of country for the company, within this export plan.

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Main research question:

How can BEEEX successfully export their business to the Belgian market in the year of 2023.

Sub-questions:

- 1) What will BEEEX's business plan and export strategy be, considering the strategic choice of exporting into Belgium, the cultural differences, challenges, and opportunities, as well as the CSR trends in the export country in 2023?
- 2) How will BEEEX's earning model and value creation be impacted by the export to Belgium in 2023?
- 3) What is the BEEEX's ideal operational plan, including internal organization, legal aspects, and CSR strategies to realize the export into Belgium in 2023?
- 4) Which SMART marketing objectives will BEEEX's export plan include, and how will they align with the export strategy for 2023?
- 5) What will BEEEX's export marketing mix look like, according to the 5P's of Marketing, in the year of 2023?
- 6) What kind of legal and financial implications will have to be thought of, to be able to safely and successfully export BEEEX to Belgium in 2023?

2.3. Research methods

Desk- and field research make up the majority of the research methodology presented in the report. The qualitative research, which entails gathering non-numerical data (Bhandari, 2020), will be carried out through communication with Beex's founder, Bieke van Orten. Qualitative research is carried out according to feedback from our client's and the teachers' during the pitch presentation held on the 2nd of November 2022. On the other hand, quantitative research, which represents research and strategy techniques (Quantitative Research: What It Is, Tips & Examples, 2022), will be used through models such as the Ansoff Growth Matrix one or the Porter's generic strategy, and so on. A variety of diverse models, including PESTLE and SWOT analysis, and Hofstede model among others, are used to conduct quantitative research. Using multiple different kinds of research methods is called triangulation (Verhoeven, 2019). Answers to the sub- and central questions are concluded in chapter 6. Conclusion of the report. Each chapter of the report was the subject of research by the team members, and the various findings were combined in order to achieve a comprehensive report on every component discussed.

3. Business plan and strategy

“Imagine you're setting out on a journey. You know what your final destination is, but you haven't figured out how to get there. While it might be fun to just start driving and figure things out as you go, your trip will most likely take longer than you anticipated and cost you more. If you instead take a look at a map and chart the best way to get to your destination, you'll arrive on time and on budget.” (Parsons, 2022).

Setting up a complete business plan and strategy can majorly impact the way the export of BEEEX will go and how successful they will be in the country of export. Different models and theories like the Ansoff Growth Matrix and Porters generic strategy, the business model canvas, swot and pestle analysi, can be utilized to add reliability to this research.

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The chosen strategy to export BEEEX, will consist of keeping the existing business & earning model, since it is working well for the company, and join a new market of the export country with this already existing product, which results in a so-called Market Development strategy. Furthermore, different aspects of this strategy will be analyzed as well as certain adjustments will be proposed that would help to adapt to the export countries market.

BUSINESS MODEL CANVAS

There is still some research to be done after selecting Belgium as the exporting country for Beex. We can use the business model canvas to see how Beex would operate as a company in our chosen country.

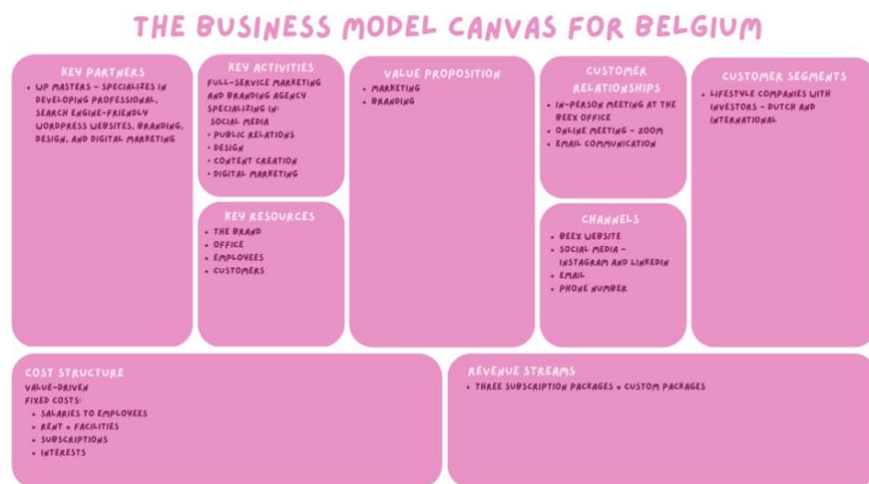


Figure 1. *Business Model Canvas for Belgium.*

3.1. Strategic choice (Belgium)

Multiple countries were researched during the initial phase of Beex's exportation in order to select the best option. Criteria for countries have been discussed: they must be European, English or Dutch speaking, have a growing PR market, and have a high level of social media activity. Belgium, Sweden, the United Kingdom, Germany, and Italy were studied using these criteria.

As the chosen country, Belgium, it is critical to conduct a thorough external and internal market analysis. To do so, a swot analysis of Belgium will be created, following Momin's (2022) research, to present all of the opportunities, strengths, weaknesses, and threats that Beex can encounter by exporting to this country. Adding to this, a PESTLE analysis, the ANSOFF growth matrix and the Porter's generic strategy will be supporting the strategic decision to export Beex to Belgium. A thorough substantiation of each of the applied criteria that explain the choice of choosing Belgium, can be found in the Appendix F.

Substantiation on the chosen city of Antwerp can be found in 5.2.3 Place.

As Beex is exporting their whole company to another country it is important to know not only the strengths and weaknesses from the company itself, but also from the country they want to export to. Which is why a SWOT analysis about Belgium is made.

Another model used to analyze Belgium better is the PESTLE analysis. This is used by companies to track the environment they're operating in or are planning to launch a new

project/product or service. The PESTLE analysis contains of 6 different parts that must be taken into account. The political factors, the economic factors, social factors, technological factors, legal factors, and the environmental factors (Pestle analysis, 2022).

Looking at the model we can conclude that Belgium is a good country for Beex to export their company to. They have a lot of similarities with The Netherlands which makes it easier for them to settle. Besides that, Belgium scores high on various important factors like the prosperity index rating, level of income inequality and digital society. Besides that, the majority of the country speaks Dutch which makes it easier for Beex to communicate as all their content for now is in Dutch. Another positive thing about Belgium is that there are no work or residency requirements for European nationals which means it's easy for Beex to export to Belgium. Belgium is also close to the Netherlands and easily accessible. **Both models used for this part can be found in the Appendix H.**

Following a thorough external and internal analysis of the Belgian market, the strategic method chosen to select Belgium as the export country must now be presented. **The models, Ansoff Growth matrix and Porter's generic strategy, analysis can be found in the Appendix H.**

BEEEX has always been all about being an intimate team really focusing on creating long lasting relationships with their clients. Therefore, a differentiation strategy is the way to go here. With this, BEEEX will be a company fully focused on the quality of their product and compete with other agencies based on their quality of work instead of their price.

3.2. Cultural aspects

The Hofstede model was developed by Geert Hofstede in 1980. The model is a framework used to understand the differences in culture across countries and to discern the ways that business is done across different cultures (Corporate Finance Institute, 2022). The model will be used to compare the similarities and differences between Belgium and the Netherlands. According to Hofstede, six categories define culture: power distance, individualism vs collectivism, masculinity vs femininity, uncertainty avoidance, long term orientation vs. short term orientation and indulgence vs. Restraint. The analysis of the model can be found in the Appendix D.

As seen in Appendix D, the analysis shows that the Belgian and Dutch culture show lots of similarities like their indulgent, pragmatic, independent society that will create great opportunities to form an efficient, positive, and thriving team. Still, there will be challenges that have to be considered, like the difference in management styles due to the higher Belgian power distance and the overall uncertainty of Belgian culture when working with people outside of their circle. Making sure that the future Belgian BEEEX team is aware and comfortable with the more participative Dutch management style in the Dutch office and possibly changing the style to a more hierarchy based one for the Belgian team, that will consider of a manager, assistant, and freelancers, could be solutions for this. This would also help navigating the independence but power distance issue of Belgian culture, making the employees feel included in the team and part of a clear hierarchy, but still independent people working for their own benefit.

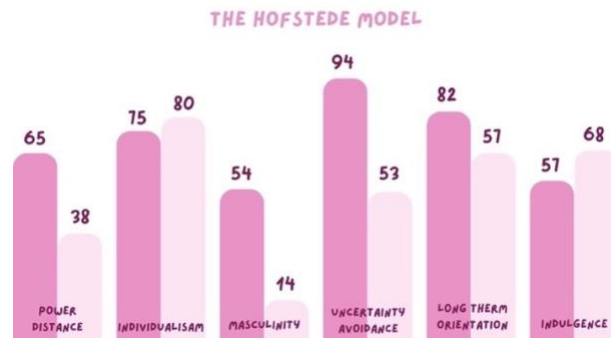


Figure 5. *Hofstede model* (Source: Hofstede Insights, 2021)

The Venn diagram has also been used in order to have further analysis of the cultural differences. It can be found in the Appendix I.

3.3. Earning Model

The method for managing a company's revenue streams and the resources needed for each revenue stream is called a revenue model (The Founder Institute, 2018). As mentioned in the SWOT analysis in Beex's organizational report, the current revenue model of the company is one of its strengths as it helps the business stand out from the competition; as a result, Beex should continue to use the same model for its export in Belgium. The current revenue model used by Beex is the subscription model. The subscription revenue model entails providing clients with a product or service that they can pay for overtime, usually month to month or even year to year (The Founder Institute, 2018).

The subscriptions consist of three-monthly packages/subscriptions which costs 85 € per hour as listed on Beex's website (Beex, 2022) as follows (Figure 7):

- Cool Start aka “Mooie Start” consists of 10 hours per month.
- Ready for Growth aka “Klaar voor Groei” consisting of 20 hours per month.
- Strive for Gold! aka “Ga voor Goud!” consisting of 40 hours per month.

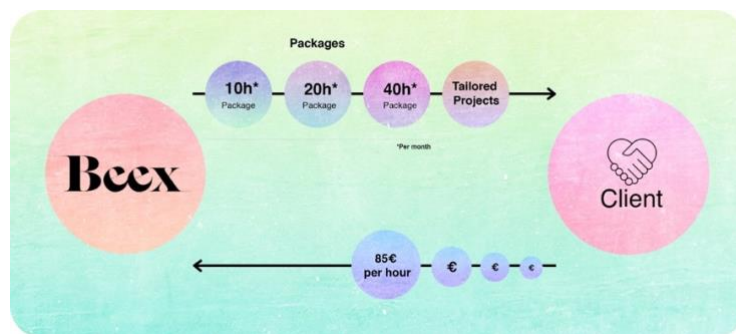


Figure 7. *Revenue model*. (Beex, 2020)

A further visualization of the five dimensions of the revenue model can be found in the Appendix G.

3.4. Value creation

Investment

Based on the financial plan we developed for Beex, we determined that having a physical office in Belgium is of high importance. The physical representation of a company communicates its identity, ethos, and values. The physical office may enhance how customers perceive a business as it serves as the focal point where stakeholders, clients, potential new employees, and even members of the press can physically experience a brand (Signify Digital, 2022). Furthermore, according to Robin Weckesser, president of a3 Workplace Strategies, a San Jose-based workplace solutions consulting firm in the United States and around the world (2022), having a physical office promotes professional development by facilitating better collaboration, making in-person communication simpler and more efficient, and promotes greater production. Additionally, there are startup costs associated with registering Beex with the Belgian Chamber of Commerce with the help of a notary. Beex has the option to invest in new computers in addition to other inventory items such as desks, screens, and other furniture, among other things.

The various investment items and their estimated total values are shown in the figure 9 below which depicts a bank loan, office rental, startup costs; a notary and a chamber of commerce registration, two computers; a MacBook Pro 13'' and an iMac 24'', and an inventory list consisting of desks, couch, screens, camera lights, printer, storage closet among others.

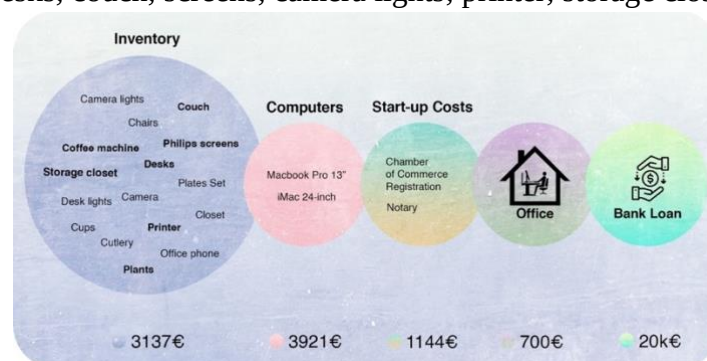


Figure 9. *Investment*. (Financial plan BEEEX team 2)

Costs

The costs for Beex in their first year in Belgium include depreciation, business costs, and salaries. Depreciation occurs when the value of a business asset decreases over time (Warnes, 2022). The depreciations apply to items in the inventory on the list previously mentioned. The business costs consist of office rent, a variety of subscriptions, and bank interest of 7.45 percent. The salaries are for a manager and an intern assistant. Each cost component is broken down into three categories alongside the total values per year in figure 10.



Figure 10. *Costs*. (Financial plan BEEEX team 2)

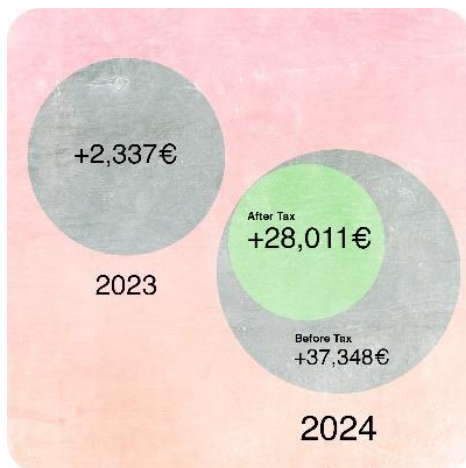


Figure 11. *Turnover and Profit.*
(Financial plan BEEEX team 2)

Turnover and Profit

The company is estimated to make a gross profit of +2,337€ and 1,753€ after taxation in its first year in Belgium in 2023. It is quite common for a startup business to not make a high profit in its first year. “99% of startup businesses I work with make a loss in year one” (Crawford, 2019). Less profit means that the company pays less or no tax, and it is carried forward onto the following years’ accounts to save even more money on taxation (Crawford, 2019). As for 2024, the company is estimated to have +37,348€ gross income and +28,011€ after taxation (see figure 11).

Alternatively, we developed a substitute financing strategy aka “plan B” with lower costs and a projected profit in the first year. The plan consists of renting shared/virtual office space with a manager and an intern assistant. Furthermore, Beex would remain using the same equipment they currently have such as computers and other items. By executing this plan, Beex will have the option of working with their current team and office in The Netherlands in addition to the employees in their shared/virtual office in Belgium. Figure 12 depicts the estimated investment/costs and profit for the alternative plan.

Please note that all amounts mentioned in the sections; “Investment”, “Costs” and “Turnover and Profit” are estimations based on research as there are no solid guarantees that can be made.



Figure 12. *Plan B finances.* (Financial plan BEEEX team 2)

3.5 Cooperate Social Responsibility

CSR or corporate social responsibility is a self-regulating business model that helps a company be socially accountable to itself, its stakeholders, and the company. By practicing CSR companies can be conscious of the kind of impact they are having on all aspects of society and besides that also promote a positive brand image of their company (Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) Explained With Examples, 2022). Belgium takes CSR very seriously and created a digital CSR knowledge center called MVO Vlaanderen, which educates on CSR and teaches business owners direct steps on how to start implementing CSR into their business strategies (Idowu, 2021, p.47).

The MVO Vlaanderen uses the triple bottom line concept to teach about implementing CSR into businesses, but also recommends other guidelines like the UN Sustainable Development Goals or the ISO 26000 (MVO Vlaanderen, 2021).

Beex is not yet focusing on CSR, but according to Beex's CEO Bieke van Orten it is on their agenda for 2024 to start investing in CSR (Personal communication client, 2022). Looking at CSR referenced to Belgium two models will be compared (see appendix E)

4. Operational Plan

4.1. Internal organization Amsterdam

The internal organization of both offices in the Netherlands and Belgium will be discussed in the following chapter. Indeed, according to Liden's research, the internal organizational structure of a company is very important because it represents the entire hierarchy, the departments covered, as well as the company's strengths and weaknesses. Having a good overview of the company structure will assist in adjusting the exporting to Belgium.

In order to do so, a model will be used, the McKinsey 7s model. This model is used to facilitate organizational change such as exporting abroad. It will help implementing a new strategy and identify how each area may change in the future by using the "7 key internal elements: strategy, structure, systems, shared values, style, staff and skills." (Jurevicius, 2022).



Figure 15. McKinsey 7s model on the company BEEX in the Netherlands.

Based on the research of Mind Tools Content Team (n.d.), this 7s model was created by following the 7 key internal elements mentioned earlier. It represents the Beex company's actual internal organization in the Netherlands. However, exporting a business to a new country may necessitate changes and adaptation to a new culture and environment. It is therefore important to identify the potential changes to apply them in the new office, the Belgian one.



Figure 16. BEEX Amsterdam team.

4.2 Internal organization Belgium

Of course, as explained earlier, the previous part determined BEEX's structure already present in the Dutch office. It has allowed us to identify the areas that have to be changed in order to adapt to the new Belgium market. Again, by using the McKinsey 7s models, the strategy, structure, system, staff, style, shared values and skills have been developed by presenting the new strategy used for the export country. The use of the model can be found in Appendix L. Overall, the strategy will remain consistent, with a continued emphasis on their all-female team and subscription-based model. The difference between the Dutch and Belgian offices is that the co-working space has replaced the rental space. In terms of personnel, only two employees will be hired for the first year, along working with three freelancers. A CSR strategy will be implemented in the Belgian office, making some changes to the shared values. In the export country, a hierarchy style will be used, as explained in the section on cultural differences. All skills that were previously handled in the Dutch office will be handled by freelancers in the Belgian office.

4.3 Legal Implications

To enter the Belgian Market safely and successfully, different legal implications must be taken into account. Since Belgium has its own company forms, regulations, and contracting norms, all these aspects must be analyzed in order to minimize risks for the company.

General

Company form: Beex is currently a private limited company in the Netherlands and must adopt this same business form in Belgium too. The name Besloten Vennootschap is in both the Netherlands and Belgium the same. But there are different rules in both the countries which must be taken into account (Pellicaan, 2019).

The private limited company is usually seen as the most suitable business form for small to medium companies. It can be established by one person and there is no minimal starting capital as long as the activities of the company have been considered. Besides that, the owner is not personally liable for any potential losses (Economie, n.d.). If you set up your company directly with the notary, it'll cost you approximately between the 800 and 1200 euros and will be done within a week. The downside to owning a private limited company compared to a proprietorship that Beex used to be is among others that there are more administrative obligations and the yearly accountant fees are higher than for a proprietorship. Another downside to owning a private limited company in Belgium is that there is the required DGA salary. This means that if you are an owner and own at least 5% of the shares, you are considered by the tax authorities as a director-major shareholder which means you are obligated to pay yourself a yearly salary of 47.000 euros (Wat Zijn De Nadelen Van Een BV?, n.d.).

Taxation: The corporate tax rate in Belgium in 2022 is 25%. For companies that are more than 50% owned by individuals or have smaller profits (less than €100.000) a lower rate of 20% is applicable. The VAT rate in Belgium is just as in the Netherlands 21%. This must be paid monthly or quarterly, and it can be reclaimed by companies on their professional expenses. Companies must file their corporate tax returns before the 30th of June electronically via the governments Biztax application (Maunder, 2022).

Regulation for Belgium:

GDPR: GDPR is the act on the protection of natural persons regarding the processing of personal data of July 30, 2018. It is a law that has been implemented within the European

Union, which means Belgium is also had to enforce the regulation (Belgium - Data Protection Overview, 2022).

Both the Belgian Data Protection Act, which went into effect on May 25th, and the General Data Protection Regulation are requirements for organizations processing personal data, which includes information on employees, customers, and business contacts (Bird & Bird LLP, 2022). Therefore, the Belgian BEEEX office will have to adhere with the GDPR just as much as the Dutch office has to. Since the Dutch Team did not enclose their specific handling of the GDPR, only recommendations for implementation can be specified. These include, ensuring that their use of personal data conforms with the General Data Protection Regulation's data protection guidelines, which include the duties of transparency (informing the data subjects of the specifics of the processing operations), security, fairness, and data quality, as well as the responsibilities to respect the rights of data subjects and having a short retention duration (Bird & Bird LLP, 2022).

The General Data Protection Regulation also requires organizations to keep a record of their processing operations, conduct a data privacy impact assessment, and, if necessary, appoint a Data Protection Officer (Bird & Bird LLP, 2022).

Employees and/or freelancers: Employees working in Belgium that have the European nationality do not need a work permit. Employees hired to work in Belgium under a Belgian employment contract will be covered by Belgian employment law. Every employer that is sending an employee to Belgium to work there temporarily are required to fill out the Limosa Declaration before the work begins. If they don't comply with this, they are facing fines and criminal charges which can reach up to 300,000 euros (Limosa - Working in Belgium, n.d.). An employer's payroll agency may handle the majority of these regulations and formalities on their behalf (Bird & Bird LLP, 2022).

Specific

Intellectual property (Registration brand name and logo): As mentioned in the organizational plan Beex doesn't have a registered trademark for either their name or logo in the Netherlands. As Belgium and the Netherlands are both part of the Benelux, it would be advisable for Beex to register their trademark at The Benelux Office for Intellectual Property. This would mean they would have a trademark for Belgium, the Netherlands and Luxembourg all in one. The trademark would be valid for 10 years and it would take approximately 3 months to complete. The costs for this would be 244 euros (Registering a Trademark in the Netherlands, 2022). Generally, Intellectual property is highly protected under Belgian laws. This makes it possible for BEEEX to theoretically continue using the name "BEEEX" without a specific trademark, which would need to be registered, but instead continue to only trust the rights under Belgian unfair competition and tort law, if they still do not wish to register (Bird & Bird LLP, 2022).

See Appendix K for further information.

Contracting: In Belgium written employment contracts are required for: fixed-term contracts, contracts for a specific assignment, part-time contracts, replacement contract, student contracts, home workers contract, contracts for temporary work. A contract for an indefinite term does not need to be in writing, however some covenants are not valid unless they are made in writing in the appropriate Belgian regional language (Van den Eynden, 2019).

The minimum wage in Belgium is not set by the law, but by collective bargaining agreements (CBA) concluded at the industry level. They have set an overall minimum wage the

‘guaranteed average monthly income’ (GAMI). The GAMI for full-time employees (as from 1 April 2022) amounts to €1806,16. The working hours in Belgium are strictly regulated. With a maximum working week of 38 hours and a maximum working day of eight hours. Besides the strict working hours employees are also entitled specific rest periods. Unless an exemption applies there must be 11 hours of uninterrupted rest per day, 24 hours of uninterrupted rest on Sunday and a rest break of 15 minutes when working more than six hours per day (unless a rest period is already determined by a CBA or a Royal Decree). Where exemptions apply, compensatory rest will usually have to be given. In Belgium paid holiday entitlements are based on the number of days worked for the current or previous employer in the year prior to the year the paid holiday is taken. If an employee has worked 5 days a week for all 12 months of the previous year, they will have a statutory right to 20 days of paid holiday. Besides that, they are entitled to 10 paid public holidays. Employees are entitled to take up to 15 weeks of maternity leave (17 weeks or 19 weeks in case of multiple births). Eligible employees are entitled to take up to 15 days of paternity leave (20 days as from 1 January 2023).

Belgium is in the midst of modernizing their civil laws, which also influences their contracting laws. Some important aspects have been added or updated to Book 5 of the Civil Code. This new Civil Code Book will be in effect starting the 1st of January 2023 and will have visible impact on contractual relationships in Belgium, which shows the importance updating of BEEEX’s Dutch contracts to the new Belgian standard for the Belgian business affairs (Loyens & Loeff, 2022).

General terms and conditions clarify each party's rights, establish a foundation for their relationship, and frequently either foresee issues or offer a means of resolving them. In Belgium, having terms & conditions is recommended but not legally required. Still, setting them in place can only be beneficial for BEEEX since their contracts would otherwise be subject to the provisions of the Civil Code which isn’t specifically set up of certain kinds of businesses but more of a universal rulebook. There are also some extra details that should be set in place like drawing up the terms & conditions at least bilingual if not trilingual, according to the official languages spoken in the country of export (hub.brussels, 2021). Adding to this, having their terms and conditions checked by a Belgian legal office would be beneficial and could let BEEEX know if they can generally continue using the same set of documents.

4.4 CSR in Belgium

According to Smith (2013), people’s perception of CSR practices makes up for 41% of how they feel about a company. This means that a CSR strategy could make a drastic difference on BEEEX’s public image, especially since genuine commitment to CSR makes media more inclined to shoutout a business (Kent, 2021). **Further information can be found in the Appendix J.**

As already discussed in 3.6 CSR, the triple bottom line concept is very widely known in Belgium and provides an easy-to-understand approach to implementing a CSR strategy for the export of BEEEX. Therefore, using this concept to form an according strategy for the new BEEEX branch in Belgium would be beneficial in many ways.

There are a few steps that BEEEX Belgium should take in order to have a solid CSR strategy that is fit for the country of export and therefore an opportunity to keep the company

competitive. Implementing these steps would let them start small to stay true to the original company and not change all of their usual practises, while still implementing CSR.

Profit

One thing that has always made BEEEX stand out from competitors is their transparency about pricing and the kind of work they provide. This idea can be taken and further developed. Being fully honest and not having any hidden terms and conditions is something that could be seen as an act of CSR. BEEEX takes responsibility for what they advertise and what services the clients end up getting at which price. They should also take this idea and use it for marketing purposes as well, being honest about slowly implementing CSR into their company and trying their best, instead of faking a massive CSR campaign that no one actually stand behind. Adding to focusing on their transparent practices and pricing, when looking for potential clients, BEEEX can start focusing on specifically clients that work sustainably or sell sustainable products.

People

The importance of fair working environments that give employees benefits and the possibility to have a great work and life balance are on the rise and are getting more and more common. This is something that BEEEX could focus on too. As explained in the internal organization, the BEEEX Belgium employees will start off working in the office twice a week and staying in home office the rest of the working days. Furthermore, team activities like drinks after work every Friday or team breakfast every Monday could positively influence the relationships within the team and attract future employees. Adding to this free occasional training and workshops should be made possible for those employees that feel the need to further learn about certain aspects of their job or research about new ideas and skills that could improve their workforce. Since BEEEX is an all women team, they can also start focusing more on this aspect by possibly donating a certain amount of their revenue to organizations for women in need, equal rights, and representation, as well as nonprofits like think pink, a national Belgian breast cancer organization, that supports affected women and their families. This would be a great way to start working with partnerships, since they are a great opportunity to engage in all kinds of CSR.

Planet

For BEEEX partnerships could be implemented concerning multiple CSR aspects. First and foremost, though, to be able to fulfill the last P of the 3P model, the Planet, a partnership with either a company that focuses on sustainability or possibly a charity that works towards helping the planet would be beneficial. Tough, because BEEEX Amsterdam does not have any values concerning being specifically green, starting a partnership like that could come off as ingenuine, which is why they can focus on working together with brands that do fit to their work directly but provide sustainable services and products. In accordance to this, a possible option would be choosing a coworking space that is designed sustainably and focuses on well-being, like Greenhouse, Antwerp. Other possible partners could be their freelancers or print businesses, as well as studios for photoshoots. In addition to partnering up with sustainable businesses, implementing overall more sustainable

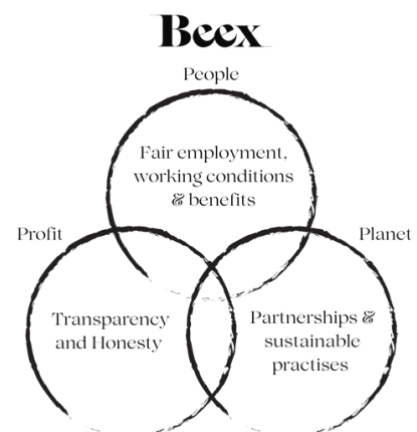


Figure 17. BEEEX Belgium 3P's model

practices like the Dutch way of commuting, biking, or taking the train or bus instead of flying when going from the headquarters in Amsterdam to Belgium would already do a lot of good. In conclusion, there are lots of actions BEEEX Belgium could take in order to create a full CSR strategy. Still, they may also choose to seek guidance in regards of implementing their CSR strategy from a CSR consulting firm. More information can be found in the appendix (Appendix – CSR Strategy).

5 Marketing plan

5.1. Marketing objectives

Marketing objectives are the outcomes a brand wants to generate from their marketing activities. They get developed using the SMART method. Without marketing objectives, the goals from a company will lack clarity and follow-through.

Objective 1

Brand awareness

Increase the brand awareness of Beex by 50% in the first year of export to Belgium by social media advertisement.

„Because it includes all of the linkages in the minds of customers that are tied to that brand, brand awareness is the most important component of brand equity “(Ismael, 2022).

When exporting to a new country, brand awareness must be built within the new market and the future clientele. “(...) the more aware consumers are of your product and your brand, the more likely they are to buy from you“ (Gustafson & Chabot, 2007). As Beex is currently unknown in Belgium more brand awareness is needed to become successful. A clear strategy to create brand awareness is necessary. Promoting their company by using social media advertisement targeted to the right target audience can increase the brand awareness from Beex (see chapter 5.2.4).

Aspects like engaging in CSR practices that focus on the local community and the companies’ products (see CSR Belgium chapter 4.4), are also proven to improve a company’s brand image as well as customer awareness, especially for smaller sized companies (Ismael, 2022).

KPI’s for brand awareness campaigns will be the number of impressions, CTR, as well as unique users (Kovalenko, 2021). Specific to the mentioned CSR practices, KPI’s will be customer retention rates, feedback, and overall involvement, as well as community participation (CSR Growth, 2021).

Objective 2

Website and social media traffic/reach

Increase website and social media traffic by 30% within the first six months in Belgium by promotion. Increasing the website and social media traffic from Beex can be done in multiple ways. Firstly, the social media accounts from Beex will be promoted so that they can reach more people. Besides that, there will be even more posts about Beex as a company and their clients on social media which will also lead the clients to the website. And it is also important that the website will be available in English besides being available in Dutch, so that it can reach even more people (see objective 5).

In addition to using social media and adding language options, SEO can also be utilized to increase website traffic. When researching Marketing & PR agencies, BEEX does not show up in the first few google pages. But “In general, high ranked sites on SERP appears more frequently in search result list and therefore receive more traffic from search engine user. This traffic or visitors can then be converted into customers“(Terrance et al., 2017). Using SEO tools like Google Search Console, SEMrush or SmallSEOTools to monitor important aspects (Terrance et al., 2017) or paying for a good ranking in search engine results (Terrance et al., 2017) can be helpful. As seen in promotional plan, this can also be outsourced. KPI’s for SEO include metrics like local organic traffic, new organic traffic, organic impressions, dwell time, bounce rate, keyword ranking or click through rate (Greene, 2022).

Objective 3

Acquire new clients

Finding at least 5 clients until the end of 2023 is crucial for our client. It is important that we attract new clients in Belgium starting the month before Beex enters the market in order to increase Beex's revenue and brand visibility. To cover the majority of the costs affiliated with exporting to a new country, clients must be acquired whose subscriptions generate monthly revenue (see Profit and Loss, Financial Plan XX). Clients will be acquired through Beex's current network and previous Belgian clients (Personal communication, 2022), as well as a promotional campaign (discussed further in 5.3). The success of this objective can then be measured by the percentage of customer acquisition throughout the year (Klipfolio, n.d.). Here are five potential clients for Beex:

Essentiel Antwerp is known for its fresh, surprising, and luxurious fashion, with unique graphic and floral prints and trendy color combinations. The one-of-a-kind collections are intended to elicit an emotional response in everyone (*Essentiel Antwerp - About Us*, n.d.).

Handbags created in Antwerp and handcrafted in Italy and Tunisia. They are built to last and use high-quality leather and craftsmanship. A transparent production process and a desire to do less and better in all areas are desirable and the only option for them (*About Lies Mertens - Consciously Designed Handbags - Antwerp*, n.d.).

Objective 4

Building brand image

Improve brand perception among Beex’s target audience by 25% within the first 6 months of its export to Belgium through the incorporation of CSR initiatives that align with the company’s values and the interests of the target audience. This will demonstrate Beex’s commitment to responsible and ethical business practices, further enhancing its brand image and reputation.

CEO Bieke has indicated that the company plans to focus on CSR initiatives in the near future (Personal communication, 2022). Furthermore, implementing CSR was identified in the organizational report for Beex as one of the opportunities for the company. This aligns with the growing trend of consumers and other stakeholders prioritizing companies that operate in a socially and environmentally responsible manner (Heyward, 2020). By prioritizing CSR, Beex can improve its brand perception and attract more customers who are looking to support businesses that are making a positive impact on society (Hubbart, 2022). One way in which CSR can improve a company's brand perception is by making the company more appealing to

consumers who are increasingly interested in supporting businesses that are making positive contributions to society and the environment “If a company is known for supporting environmental causes or fair labor practices, consumers may be more likely to view the company favorably and choose to do business with them over a company that does not have a strong CSR record.” (Vaughan, 2021). This objective can be measured by surveying for instance.

Objective 5

Making BEEEX more international

Focusing on the international market can help attract more clients and partners. To that end, the goal is to add an English option to the website as well as a French, German and Spanish one, as the current one is only available in Dutch, and the company is mainly focusing on a European audience. According to new research, creating a multi-language website will undoubtedly help reach a larger audience. Indeed, 25% of internet users are native English speakers, and incorporating the English option will assist in reaching this audience. 7% of internet users are Spanish speakers, 3% are French, and 2% are German speakers, not to mention that Belgium is divided into three linguistic regions: Dutch, French, and German (O’Hare, 2022; Statista, 2022b). Introducing these options to the website will thus help reach at least 30% of internet users by 2023. To create a multilingual website, simply add an expansion that detects the website's native language (here, Dutch) and automatically translates to the language chosen. Only the option to change the language needs to be included (*9 Tips for Designing a Multi Language Website*, 2022).

5.2. Marketing Mix

The Marketing Mix 5 Ps is an important tool for assisting us in selecting and developing the best marketing strategies for our client. It is beneficial to consider which aspects of Beex as a business should be changed or improved in order to help us and our clients meet the needs of the desired Belgium market, add value, and differentiate the product or service from competitors.

According to Borden (1964), a marketing mix consists of a list of elements including Product, Pricing, Branding, Channels of distribution, Personal selling, Advertising, Promotions and many more. For this marketing mix, the focus will lay on the Product sold, the price it will be sold for, the place it will be sold from, as well as the promotional activities to do so and the people & resources needed. The first four elements are also known as the 4P’s, further developed after Borden’s article, by E. Jerome McCarthy (Twin, 2022).

5.2.1. Product

“Creating a marketing campaign starts with an understanding of the product itself. “ (Twin, 2022). While exporting Beex to Belgium we want to keep their way of working as similar as possible. This includes their product. Beex's current products include subscription packages of 10, 20, and 40 hours. For those who are unsure how many hours they require, there is also a tailor-made project where you can request the number of hours you require. The 10-hour project is ideal if you have a small business or want to outsource some of your marketing and branding activities to a professional. Consider social media, design, or public relations activities. You can request extensive management of your social media channels, including content creation, or a new awesome house style for all of your communication expressions with the 20-hour project. The 40-hour package is designed for those who want to fill their time with photo shoots, content creation, house styling, promotional material design, and a variety of other activities. There are also custom projects available if you are unsure which package is best for you or if your preference is not listed (Beex, 2020).



Figure 18. *BEEX packages*

Adaption to the Belgian market:

“Many of the most successful products have been the first in their category. “ (Twin, 2022). Since BEEEX’s subscription model is new to the Belgian PR market, it has lots of potential to be successful. Still, also offering project-based services instead of only monthly subscriptions, just like in the Amsterdam office, will be the key to adapting to the Belgian market and slowly introducing this new model into the existing market.

5.2.2. Price

According to Beex's export financial plan for Belgium in 2023, there are three types of freelancers who work to fulfill subscription orders from clients. For example, if a client orders a 20-hour monthly package, one or more freelancers must work for that number of hours to produce the desired products for the client. Figure 19 illustrates how three types of freelancers work based on subscription orders (Nr. Of Expected Sales) alongside, variable costs, total costs, and sales prices.

Roles	Nr. of Expected Sales	Variable Costs (per year)	Total Cost (per hour)	Sales Price (per hour)
PR Specialist	801 hours	36,851€	56€	79€
Designer	653 hours	48,116€	80€	84€
Social Media Manager	1131 hours	71,925€	64€	89€

Figure 19. *BEEEX's financial plan.*

Beex currently charges 85€ per subscription hour, as they have informed us personally (Personal communication client). According to the example of freelancers working to complete the subscription hours (Figure F), having a fixed price per subscription hour may not be profitable in all cases, because some employees or freelancers cost more than others and

multiple entities have to put in the work for these hours, who vary in cost per client. Still, in the curated financial plan, the company is estimated to have a revenue of 219649€ and expected sales hours of 2585 hours, hence the subscription hour remains 85€. This amount was calculated as an average taking into consideration the expected sales of hours in the first year (total revenue divided by the total number of hours).

In order to support our pricing strategy, we conducted extensive market research and discovered that relatively few digital marketing firms in Belgium offer subscription-based services similar to those provided by Beex and those that do offer such services typically do not publicly disclose pricing information, requiring potential clients to contact the company directly. However, we did identify one digital marketing and social media firm, Adman Agency (2023), that utilizes a subscription-based revenue model and provides pricing information on their website. As seen in the accompanying figure 20, Adman's pricing ranges from 90€ to 100€ per hour (Adman Agency, 2023). This serves as a positive indication that Beex's pricing strategy surpasses that of our competitors by offering more competitive rates.

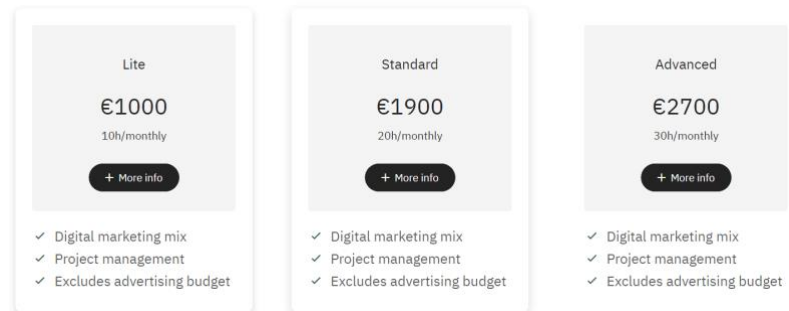


Figure 20. (Adman Agency, 2023)

It is important to note that the cost of a subscription hour includes time, effort, hassle, and money. These expenses are borne by the freelancers, public relations specialists, designers, and social media managers who work on the project(s), including the time spent on such. The PR specialist's responsibilities include planning and implementing public relations campaigns, writing and distributing press releases and speeches/posts on social media, managing relationships with journalists and social media influencers, and representing the organization at public events (BLS, 2022). Designers are responsible for creating concepts, graphics, and layouts for a variety of mediums and social media platforms, as well as websites, brochures, and various other types of advertising (Targetjobs, 2023). Finally, the social media manager is in charge of overseeing a company's interactions with the public by implementing the content strategies of social media platforms. Their responsibilities include analyzing engagement data, identifying trends in customer interactions, and developing digital campaigns to build online communities (Pavlou, 2022).

In conclusion, the price of a subscription hour varies depending on variables associated with providing the subscription hours, such as variable costs, revenue projection, and other types of expenses.

Hiring freelancers can be costly. However, even though freelancers may have higher hourly rates than employees, their primary advantage is that clients only pay for the hours they have worked productively. Additionally, freelancers typically use their own equipment, allowing clients to save money (Rühl, 2021).

5.2.3. Place

After discussing which city would be most suitable for our client, we agreed on Antwerp. Antwerp is a cosmopolitan city in the heart of Europe with a small footprint. It is situated at the crossroads of northern and southern cultures, making it an ideal testing ground for new products, designs, or retail concepts. In comparison to other European cities, living and working in Antwerp is still affordable. All of the tools for success are right outside your door. Metropolitan-scale networks, infrastructure, competencies, and support organizations are available, but with the convenience of a small town. In a nutshell, Antwerp is a city large enough to matter but small enough to care (Business in Antwerp, n.d.).



Figure 21. *Facts and Figures of Antwerp, Belgium.* (Business in Antwerp, n.d.)

“Place is the consideration of where the product should be available “(Twin, 2022). BEEEX Belgium will be working and offering their service based in Antwerp. Antwerp has been chosen because of its upcoming creative industry market with other trendy creative agencies already at location (HousingAnywhere, 2022). Seeing that other creative agencies are already there, gives a good idea of what the market there has to offer for BEEEX. Antwerp also is home to the Royal Academy of fine arts as well as the AP hogeschool Antwerp, which offers courses like Content Marketing, Graphic and Digital Media, Journalism & Marketing. This will be a benefit when looking for possible employees or interns for their business there. Overall, being present in Belgium is a must for the export of BEEEX. BEEEX is focused on creating a good relationship and network with their clients, so being able to meet them in person and also having an address in Antwerp will be crucial to be considered part of the market and therefore have a realistic chance to compete with other local marketing agencies.

Looking at market data supporting this decision of going to Belgium specifically, one notices how the Belgian PR industry has been seeing a steady rise in industry revenue and is expected to continue getting higher, with 2,24 mil USD revenue in 2022 and an expected revenue of 2,32 mil USD in 2023 (Statista, 2021b). Together with the rising spending on digital advertisement, which has increased from 27% in 2016 (Statista, 2023b) to 34,5% in 2021 (Statista, 2023a) and its therefore close distance to surpassing ad spending on TV, this data gives a clear indication on how well the Belgium PR & advertising market is doing. For BEEEX to establish themselves now would let them have an active part in the development of the Belgian PR and digital advertising industry. For visualizations regarding the place market data check appendix M.

Considering this, either working from a co working space or renting an own office space would be possible, although when starting off in the first year limiting the costs is important which would make a co working office a smarter choice to start off with. Possible option, that also fit to the set-up CSR strategy could be places like Greenhouse, a sustainable co working space (Greenhouse Offices, 2022).

As Beex is only starting in Belgium they don't need as big of an office as they have in Amsterdam. Which is why in Belgium they'll be moving into a shared office. Initially this will be located in Antwerp. As Beex is a Dutch speaking company and Antwerp is one of the biggest Dutch speaking cities in Antwerp. But as they might also want to do business in the capital of Belgium Brussels, they could look into hiring an office space at for instance Silversquare. They have multiple offices in Brussels, but soon also in Antwerp. Here they can rent out either private office spaces each month at one place but could also for around 325 euros a month hire a place in each of Silversquare offices. This includes 24/7 entry to the office, coffee, tea and water and use of the shared as well as private rooms. This way Beex can easily organize meetings in Belgium with their clients, and work at an own office space. But are not prohibited to use it if they don't need it (Unieke coworkingruimtes in België & Luxemburg. | Silversquare, n.d.).

Since Antwerp belongs to the Dutch part of Belgium, keeping the main language of business in Dutch will make the export feel even more natural and won't necessarily require much adjustment, as for their website or socials, since they will be understood in Dutch. Being able to keep Dutch as their main language within the team will also be beneficial, since "sharing the same languages could enhance performance in both collaborative insight problem-solving and divergent thinking tasks in multilingual teams potentially through better and more efficient communicative and collaborative processes." (Quin Yow & Zhao Ming Lim, 2019). Still, giving international clients the option to see an English translation would be something that could increase clientele since it would open up BEEEX for more international clients as well. Considering that about 13% of the population, or close to 1.5 million people, were born outside of the country, Belgium is a multicultural place that could require the addition of English translation to fully accept BEEEX into their quite international market (Expatica, 2022c).

5.2.4. Promotion and communication

Beex will use a variety of marketing tactics to promote its services, including social media marketing, content marketing, and search engine optimization. The company may also use more traditional marketing tactics such as media coverage in three high-profile outlets and networking with potential clients. Beex may use targeted social media advertising to reach specific demographics or interests and focus on increasing the number of subscription sales by offering incentives or discounts for long-term contracts.

"Promotion refers to specific and thoughtful advertising that reaches the target market for the product" (Twin, 2022).

To communicate to the Belgian market and promote BEEEX in the country of export, both offline and online advertising should be considered.

Circling back to the SMART marketing objectives in 5.1, one of the objectives was the increase of overall reach by increasing website clicks through using SEO tools like Google Search. Utilizing SEO has many benefits for BEEEX (as seen in Figure 23) and could easily be

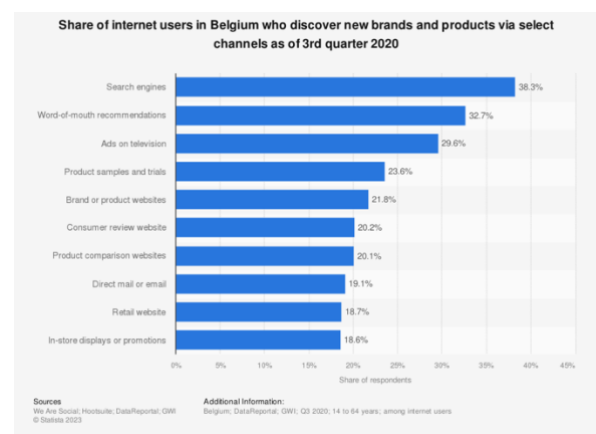


Figure 22. Channels of brand discovery with shares (Statista, 2023c)

outsourced for a approx. price of 1250 euros a month. Of course, this would be an investment, but it could massively help getting BEEEX known in Belgium, especially, since the majority Belgians, discover companies through search engines, as seen in figure 22.

Another way of promoting BEEEX in Belgium would be using social media. Currently BEEEX does have social media presence but is not actively promoting their service on multiple outlets. According to the CEO Bieke van Orten, they are mostly using their build network to acquire new clients, instead of focusing on actively advertising their company (personal communication, 2022). Since they will have no, to limited connection already available to them in Belgium, using their social media outlets more actively to promote the new branch will be useful. According to Statista (2021a), Social media advertising's impact in the Dutch-speaking region of Belgium in 2019 and 2020 has been growing for nearly every age group. This shows how using social media will be more and more influential. To be able to realize a social media campaign, one can outsource this for approx. 450 euros a month (Belgium WebNet, n.d.).

Finally, as already mentioned in prior chapters, local involvement is especially important. Promoting BEEEX Belgium on a local scale in Antwerp and area, will be another way of promotion to consider. One way to do this, with benefits like credibility, affordability, visibility and, the wanted local impact, would be a poster campaign (CEO Today, 2019). Since the BEEEX team already has lots of talented creatives in the house, creating a fitting poster would be no issue. Another way to gain local exposure and boost BEEEX's new Belgium Branch would be trough local events. BEEEX could either sponsor an event or even just donate their service and offer free PR services for the event in question. This way, the name BEEEX will get known and they will gain lots of potential customer data as well as more and more local networking connections (FreeLogoServices, 2017). A different way to becoming part of the local creatives' scene would be offering workshops and listing them with ANTWERP. POWERED BY CREATIVES., a platform for connections that encourages collaboration between the creative industry and other sectors in the province of Antwerp, inspires businesspeople to create, and aids in the expansion of creative businesses (ANTWERP. POWERED BY CREATIVES., n.d.).

By following all, or even just one of these three promotional plans, BEEEX Belgium will be able to become part of the local network and therefore ideally reach the set marketing objectives.

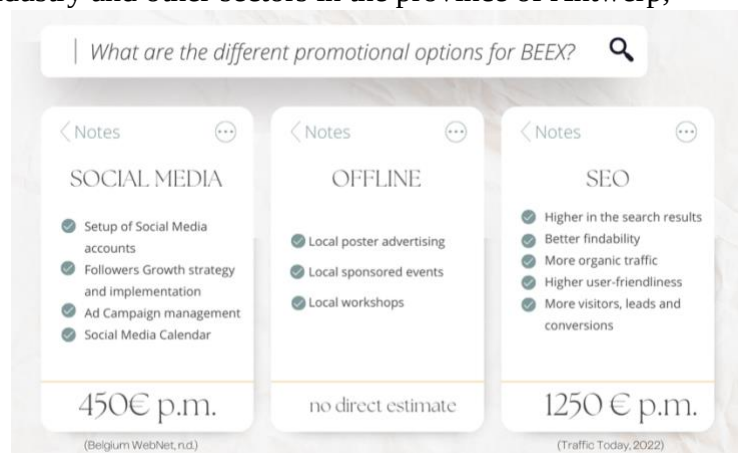


Figure 23. BEEEX promotional option.

5.2.5. People

The Beex team in the Netherlands consists of 8 woman who are all expertised in different areas of marketing. As the company in Belgium for now won't be as big as the one in the Netherlands, not that many employees are needed. Which is why it's decided to besides one manager and intern work with freelancers. There will be three freelancers at the start,

with all three a different area they are specialized in. A PR specialist, a designer, and a social media manager. In this strategy the manager will be in close contact with the team in the Netherlands and will lead the freelancers in doing the right thing for the clients.

5.3. Legal implications

After creating the marketing mix and specifically the promotional plan, some more legal implications must be analyzed, to ensure all aspects mentioned can be used and went ahead with, without any legal issues.

The use of targeted social media advertising, partnerships, search optimization, and media coverage are all practices that may have significant legal implications in Belgium. This section aims to examine the legal issues surrounding these practices and to explore the potential legal marketing plan consequences for Beex's export to Belgium. We will examine the legal implications of targeted social media advertising, explore the legal considerations that apply to partnerships, including the rights and obligations of the partners, as well as the impact on clients of the partnership, and legal issues surrounding search optimization, and we will examine the legal considerations that apply to media coverage in Belgium. **All of this research can be found in the Appendix C.**

5.4. Financial Substantiation

The cost of social media advertising, partnerships or sponsorships, search optimization, and local promotion in Belgium will depend on a number of factors, including the goals of the marketing plan mentioned previously, the target audience, the budget allocated for the marketing efforts set by Beex, and the resources available to the business. In order to develop a financial substantiation that includes these elements, Beex will need to consider the costs associated with each aspect of the marketing plan and how these costs will be offset by the expected returns on investment (Egger, 2022).

Beex may need to consider the costs of creating and implementing targeted social media advertising campaigns, including the cost of creating ads which Beex could take care of as it's their field of expertise, targeting specific audiences and tracking the effectiveness of the campaigns which are done through social media management tools. The table below (2) shows the costs for different social media platforms (Auer, 2022).

Platform	Cost
Google	An average cost of 2€ - 4€ cost per click.
TikTok	Ads start at 10€ per CPM (cost per thousand).
Instagram	An average cost of 1.18€ cost per click.
Facebook	The average cost per click is about 0.35€.
YouTube	Ads have an average cost-per-view of 0.010€ – 0.030€, which likely sums up to an average of 10€ a day.

As seen in Figure 22, they could also outsource this for an approximate of around 450 euros a month.

Beex may also need to consider the costs of partnerships and sponsorships in Belgium, including any fees or commissions that are paid to partners or sponsors, as well as the cost of any marketing or promotional efforts that are undertaken as part of the partnership (Binder, 2020).

In addition, Beex will need to consider the costs associated with search optimization in Belgium, including the cost of implementing SEO strategies, such as keyword research and

content creation, as well as the cost of any paid search advertising. They may choose to outsource for this part of the marketing plan, however, SEOs cost ranges between 50€ - 200€ per hour (Wimmer, 2022). As seen in figure 22, specific SEO companies will take around 1250 euros a month for these services.

Finally, Beex will need to consider the costs of local promotion like e.g., a poster campaign. Putting a poster in a bus station will cost you around 135 euros for one poster (Adverteerderweb, 2022). As Beex obviously is a marketing and PR agency they don't have to hire people to design the posters as they can do that their selves.

By carefully considering the costs and potential returns associated with each aspect of the marketing plan in Belgium, Beex can develop a financial substantiation that accurately reflects the costs and benefits of the marketing efforts and helps to guide decision-making and resource allocation (Fischer, 2021).

Promotion

As mentioned above Beex will be promoted with online social media promotion as well as OOH advertisement to reach even more people. Putting a poster in a bus station will cost you around 135 euros for one poster (Adverteerderweb, 2022). As Beex obviously is a marketing and PR agency they don't have to hire people to design the posters as they can do that their selves.

6. Problem Definition and Analysis

What will BEEEX's business plan and export strategy be, considering the strategic choice of exporting into Belgium, the cultural differences, challenges, and opportunities, as well as the CSR trends in the export country in 2023?

The created business plan intends to send BEEEX on the smoothest journey possible by outlining the substantiation on why Belgium is the right choice of country with as many market-based, up to date sources and data of e.g., the PR industry growth, political factors, potential new clients for BEEEX on location as well as many more details all about the choice of Belgium. Strategically, BEEEX, will keep the existing business & earning model, since it is working well for the company, and join a new market of the export country with this already existing product, which results in a so-called Market Development strategy. Culturally, Belgium and The Netherlands did not end up being very different, with only some dimensions of the used Hofstede 6D model showing clear differences in work culture, that could possibly pose as a challenge. Still, by advising to prioritize open conversations about these topics and making use of the similarities as opportunities to form an efficient & positive team, the cultural differences should not pose a threat to this export. When it comes to the Belgian CSR trends and the two presented CSR models, the Triple Bottom Line Model offers the most fitting, simple overview of what implementing CSR means for a company and is also common in Belgium, hence its use for the MVO Vlaanderen

How will BEEEX's earning model and value creation be impacted by the export to Belgium in 2023?

BEEEX's current earning model consisting of monthly subscription and occasional separate projects, will not be impacted by the export to Belgium. The subscription model has several advantages, including reliable recurring revenue, a strong customer base and increased customer loyalty, easier financial forecasting, increased customer lifetime value,

and reduced churn. However, the subscription model also carries some risks, including increased competition as more businesses adopt this model. In terms of value creation, Beex will need to invest in various items such as a physical office, startup costs, and inventory items in order to establish a presence in Belgium. These investments will likely have an impact on the company's overall value creation, as they will help to improve the customer experience and establish a professional image for the company. In addition to these investments, Beex will also need to consider costs such as depreciation, business costs, and salaries in order to operate their business in Belgium. By carefully managing these costs and maximizing the return on its investments, Beex can optimize its revenue model and value creation in the Belgian market. According to the created financial plan, the Belgian BEEEX branch will make an estimate first annual turnover of 219.649 € with an approximate profit of 1,753€ after taxation.

What is the BEEEX's ideal operational plan, including internal organization, legal aspects, and CSR strategies to realize the export into Belgium in 2023?

Beex will need to deploy a variety of people and resources. This will include hiring employees in Belgium, such as a manager and an assistant, as well as potentially seeking assistance from their current team in the Netherlands. Beex will also need to establish a physical office in Belgium, which will require acquiring equipment and inventory items. Good communication will be important in order to maintain contact with customers and ensure that projects are completed effectively.

In terms of legal implications, Beex will need to consider the various legal requirements for establishing and operating a business in Belgium. This will include choosing the appropriate business structure, such as a limited liability company or open limited liability company, and complying with governance, capital, and corporate tax requirements. In terms of employment, Beex will need to follow Belgian employment law, including provisions related to minimum wage, working hours, and employees' and freelancers' rights. It will also be important to consider any regulatory requirements or permits that may be needed in order to do business in Belgium such as GDPR, intellectual property, and logo and name registration. By carefully navigating these legal considerations, Beex can ensure that they are operating in compliance with Belgian laws and regulations. When it comes to CSR strategies, Beex will need to consider how it can contribute to the local community and minimize its environmental impact in Belgium according to the triple bottom line model consisting of the 3Ps (Profit, People, Planet). This could involve Profit: Beex could focus on transparent pricing and targeting clients that sell sustainable products to improve their CSR efforts. People: Beex could prioritize fair working environments, team-building activities, and training opportunities for employees as part of its CSR strategy. Planet: Beex could partner with sustainable businesses and implement more sustainable practices to improve their CSR efforts. Taking a proactive approach to CSR, Beex can demonstrate its commitment to social and environmental responsibility, which can help to enhance its reputation and build long-term relationships with customers, employees, and other stakeholders.

EXPORT PLAN REPORT

Which SMART marketing objectives will BEEEX's export plan include, and how will they align with the export strategy for 2023?

To ensure the success of its export plan in 2023, BEEEX should include SMART marketing objectives. BEEEX might consider setting the following marketing objectives for its export plan:

- A. Increase the brand awareness of Beex by 50% in the first year of export to Belgium through social media advertisement.
- B. Increase website and social media traffic by 30% within the first six months in Belgium by promotion.
- C. Attract new clients in Belgium starting the month before Beex enters the Belgium market to increase the revenue from Beex and their brand visibility.
- D. Improve brand perception among Beex's target audience by 25% within the first 6 months of its export to Belgium through the incorporation of CSR initiatives that align with the company's values and the interests of the target audience.
- E. Introducing a multilingual option to the website to reach a wider audience will help reach at least 30% of internet users by 2023.

By setting clear, measurable, and achievable objectives, Beex can track its progress and make adjustments to its export plan as needed in order to achieve success in the Belgian market in 2023. The goals are to raise brand awareness, increase website and social media traffic, attract new clients, reach a wider audience with a multilingual website and improve brand perception. All of these objectives are directly related to Beex's success in the Belgian market and appear to be well aligned with the export strategy established as they are likely to contribute to the overall success of the export strategy. Overall, these marketing objectives provide Beex with a clear road map to follow as it works to establish itself in the Belgian market and achieve its export goals.

What will BEEEX's export marketing mix look like, according to the 5P's of Marketing, in the year of 2023?

For Product, Beex will maintain a similar way of working, including its package offerings in its export to Belgium, and will adapt to the Belgian market by also offering project-based services in addition to its subscription model as they do in The Netherlands. As for Price, prices for Beex's subscription-based services will be determined on a case-by-case basis, taking into account the specific requirements and costs of each client. When it comes to Place, Antwerp was chosen as the ideal location for the client due to its upcoming creative market, good employee recruitment options through the local universities, as well as the spoken Dutch language and . Regarding Promotion, Beex will use a variety of tactics to increase brand awareness and attract new clients in Belgium including targeted social media advertising, content marketing, search engine optimization, offline local promotion, and local events sponsorship or participation. Finally, for People, the Beex team in Belgium will consist of one manager, one intern, and three freelancers specializing in PR, design, and social media management while maintaining close communication with the larger team in the Netherlands.

What kind of legal and financial implications will have to be thought of, to be able to safely and successfully export BEEEX to Belgium in 2023?

Beex will have to consider the legal implications of various marketing practices such as targeted social media advertising, search optimization, content marketing, offline local promotion, and local event sponsorship or participation in order to safely and successfully export their services to Belgium. These practices may have significant legal implications in Belgium, and Beex will need to investigate these legal issues to avoid any potential legal consequences. Beex must also consider the financial implications of its marketing efforts in Belgium, such as the costs of developing and implementing targeted social media advertising campaigns, partnerships and sponsorships, search optimization, and local promotion. To create a financial justification that accurately reflects the costs and benefits of its marketing efforts, Beex will need to carefully consider the costs and potential returns associated with each aspect of its marketing strategy. The costs will be determined by factors such as the marketing plan's objectives, the target audience, the marketing budget, and the budget allocated by the business.

General question

How can BEEEX successfully export their business to the Belgian market in the year of 2023?

For BEEEX to be able to successfully export their business to the Belgian market in the year of 2023, multiple steps must be put in motion.

The created business plan will have to be followed, which entails an export strategy based on research of the Belgian market, as well as important cultural differences and therefore advised changes to overcome resulting challenges while making use of opportunities. BEEEX will additionally have to consider following the advised 3P's CSR strategy with steps they can take to stay competitive against other agencies, while also positively impacting their own business and environment. Their earning model will stay the same since the subscription model has not yet made its way to the Belgian PR market and therefore will set them apart from competition. The created operational plan, with its internal organization plan that advises to employ 2 employees and work with freelancers, while staying close to the current strategy to sustain competitive advantage as well as many more detailed aspects to adhere to, will have to be realized. Furthermore, the mentioned legal aspects will have to be looked over by a legal advisor or specialized lawyer. The five SMART marketing objectives will create a guideline with fitting strategy, that will have to be checked periodically to make sure BEEEX stays on track and successfully reaches these goals that will lead to reach, clients, and brand awareness in the new market. The created marketing mix will act as a guide on how to reach these goals by outlining the product, price, people, and promotion needed to fulfill this plan, while adhering to specific legal and financial implications that come with it. By fulfilling all the said aspects of this export plan, BEEEX should be able to successfully export their business to the Belgian market in 2023.

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8. Appendix

Appendix A - CSR Strategy

As discussed in Chapter II.V. the 3Ps model is what Beex will implement when it comes to their CSR initiatives in the export country Belgium. The model also known as the triple bottom line, is a framework for measuring the sustainability of a business. The 3Ps refer

to three key dimensions of sustainability: people, planet, and profit (Rinalducci, 2022). To implement this model Beex can ask for guidance from a CSR consulting firm such as Sarko, a consulting CSR firm that helps businesses build a sustainability strategy, define measurable goals, and develop related action plans (2022). Another company that Beex can use consultation from is CleanTechFlanders which helps businesses with the implementation of clean technologies that accelerate the transition to a sustainable world (2022). Beex can work on its corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiatives by taking guidance from a CSR consulting firm as it can provide Beex expert guidance and support in developing and implementing CSR initiatives that align with Beex's values and goals (Elango, 2021). The first step in partnering with a CSR consulting firm is to identify the specific areas in which Beex wants to focus its CSR efforts -in terms of people, planet, and profit- which could include reducing its environmental impact, supporting local communities, or promoting diversity and inclusion. Once the areas of focus have been identified, the CSR consulting firm can help Beex develop a comprehensive CSR strategy that outlines the specific initiatives that the business will undertake and the goals that it hopes to achieve. This strategy should be aligned with Beex's overall business objectives and should be designed to maximize the positive impact that the company can have on the world. The consulting firm can then guide how Beex should engage with stakeholders, such as employees, customers, and local communities, as well as help to develop and implement programs and initiatives that support Beex's CSR goals. In addition to providing guidance and support during the implementation phase, the consulting firm can also help the company measure and evaluate the impact of its CSR initiatives. This can include conducting research and analysis to assess the effectiveness of the initiatives and providing recommendations for improvement.

Another approach to implementing a CSR strategy for Beex would be to carefully choose clients in Antwerp that align with the company's sustainability goals, such as



ESSENTIEL Antwerp, HNST, and la fille d'O (2022). These organizations are known for their focus on innovative, environmentally friendly products and commitment to diversity and equality initiatives.

In conclusion, engaging with a CSR consulting firm and working with clients who prioritize CSR efforts may be an effective means for Beex to pursue its CSR goals and make a positive contribution to people, the planet, and profit.

Appendix B – *Marketing Objectives*

The purpose of marketing objectives is to guide marketing efforts by outlining measurable goals for the results of a marketing strategy (Nasrudin, 2022). This section includes five marketing objectives (A - E) that were developed using the SMART method followed by in-depth descriptions. These objectives are aligned with the previously established strategy for Beex's export to Belgium and are focused on increasing sales and adapting Beex to the Belgian market.

A. Brand Awareness

Increase the overall brand awareness for the company in Belgium by 30% within the first six months of export to Belgium through targeted social media advertising.

As mentioned in the organizational report previously developed for Beex, the company's target audience is mainly lifestyle, fashion, and catering industry companies. To increase brand awareness, the campaign should focus on creating content that resonates with the target audience and encourages engagement and sharing. In research from Kondak, a targeted advertisement in online marketing is one that is shown to a particular audience, which could be a demographic, a group, or an individual. Targeted advertising can simply mean that ads are chosen with the assumption that they will also be relevant to the site's audience based on their relevance to the site's content (2022). According to Beex's website, the company is currently using Facebook, Instagram, and LinkedIn for social media channels (Beex, 2022). Facebook and Instagram are great platforms for targeted advertising as they have numerous targeting options and would help Beex to determine the most accurate picture of its target market (Kondak, 2022). This objective can be measured by social media management tools

B. Clients & Partnerships

Establish partnerships with at least three key industry players in Belgium in 2023 to increase brand visibility and reach potential clients.

As mentioned in the opportunities in Beex's organizational report, working with more clients abroad would be an opportunity for Beex to take advantage of expanding its international prospects and possible future collaborations. Partnerships can be a valuable way for businesses to attract new clients and by partnering with other companies or organizations, businesses can access new networks and customer bases, as well as gain credibility and support for their products or services (Malla, 2021). In some cases, partnerships can also lead to cost savings and other benefits that can help a business to grow and thrive (Sumner, 2021). Overall, partnerships can be an effective way for businesses to expand their reach and attract new clients.

C. Customer

Satisfaction and Retention Rates

EXPORT PLAN REPORT

Increase customer satisfaction and retention rates in 2023 in Belgium by delivering high-quality design and content for clients and increasing the number of subscription sales. The subscription model currently used by Beex allows the establishment of recurring relationships with customers and increases customer loyalty and customer lifetime value and reduced churn by making Beex's subscription offerings flexible for better customer retention (Johnson, 2022).

D. Website Traffic

Increase website traffic from Belgium by 25% within the first six months of export to Belgium through search engine optimization.

SEO, or search engine optimization, is the process of improving the visibility of a website in search engine results pages, intending to increase the amount of organic traffic that the site receives (Patel, 2020). For Beex's export, SEO can be an important tool for reaching potential customers and increasing brand awareness in the target market in Belgium. By optimizing its website for search engines, the company can increase the chances that its website will appear among the top results when potential customers in the target market search for relevant keywords as this can help to increase the visibility of the company and its products and can make it easier for customers to find and learn about the company's offerings (Hardwick, 2022). This objective can be measured by website traffic management tools.

E. Building Brand Image: Media Coverage

In the first three months of 2023, obtain at least three high-profile media placements for Beex in publications that are pertinent to the industry in order to help build brand image, drive more traffic and sales, gain credibility, and generate buzz and excitement around Beex's services (Mollah, 2021).

Obtaining media coverage can increase the visibility and credibility of a business (Oliver, 2022). These placements should be in high-profile publications in order to maximize their impact. This can help to raise Beex's profile within the industry and improve its reputation among potential customers and other stakeholders. "Positive media coverage is a powerful marketing tool because it positions you or your business in a favorable light by projecting the credibility, expertise, passion, and image you want to convey." (Netto, 2021). This objective can be measured by surveying or social media analysis for instance.

Appendix C – *Marketing Legal Implications*

In Belgium, Beex's marketing strategy which primarily focuses on utilizing social media advertising, SEO, and acquiring clients are subject to legal implications. This includes compliance with laws and regulations. Listed below are the legal consequences for each tactic. Adhering to the regulations and legislation in Belgium ensures that Beex stays clear of any legal troubles.

Search Optimization

According to Harris (2022), in general, search engine optimization (SEO) is a practice that aims to improve the ranking of a website in search engine results pages (SERPs) in order to increase the visibility and traffic to the website. In Belgium, there are no specific laws that regulate SEO practices. However, SEO practices must adhere to the guidelines and best

practices set by search engines, such as Google as these guidelines outline what is and is not acceptable in terms of SEO tactics and techniques and may be updated from time to time (Moore, 2021). In addition, SEO practices must comply with general laws and regulations related to advertising, consumer protection, and privacy (Anderson, 2020). This includes the prohibition of deceptive or misleading advertising practices, the requirement to protect the personal data of users, and the obligation to provide accurate and transparent information about products and services (Addaman, 2019). It is important for individuals and businesses engaging in SEO in Belgium to familiarize themselves with these guidelines and to ensure that their practices comply with them.

Targeted Social Media Advertising

Targeted advertising has been viewed as a violation of privacy due to its use of personal information for the purpose of targeting ads to specific individuals and it is important to recognize that all of the information that is shared online can potentially be tracked and used for targeted advertising (Acrey, 2021). This includes search queries, social media activity, and web browsing history. Advertisers often use this information to infer potential purchasing habits and preferences based on factors such as age, gender, income, and relationship status (GCFGlobal, 2020). However, targeted advertising may be not considered a violation of privacy because it is typically done with the user's consent and when a user visits a website or uses an online service, they often agree to the terms of service, which may include the collection and use of their personal information for targeted advertising purposes as many websites and online services offer users the option to opt-out of targeted advertising by adjusting their privacy settings or using tools like ad blockers (Mertens, 2020)

<https://edu.gcfglobal.org/en/thenow/what-is-targeted-advertising/1/>

Partnerships

Partnerships are a type of business structure in which two or more individuals or entities come together to conduct a business venture. In Belgium, partnerships are governed by the Belgian Code of Companies and Associations (Simon, 2020). The legal impacts of partnerships on clients in Belgium depend on the specific terms of the partnership agreement and the nature of the business venture being conducted (Denis, 2021). In general, clients of a partnership in Belgium have the right to expect that the partnership will act in a professional and transparent manner and that it will adhere to any agreements or contracts that have been made with the client (Nguyen, 2019). The contracting process for partnerships in Belgium involves the creation of a partnership agreement, which outlines the rights, responsibilities, and expectations of the partners. This agreement should be in writing and should be signed by all parties involved. It is important for the partners to carefully review and understand the terms of the partnership agreement before signing it, in order to avoid misunderstandings or disputes in the future (Benali, 2021). Moreover, the legal implications of partnerships in Belgium can be both positive and negative. On the positive side, partnerships can provide a way for businesses to share resources, knowledge, and expertise in order to achieve common goals and they can also provide a way for businesses to expand their operations and reach new markets (Jacobs, 2022). On the negative side, partnerships can be complex and may involve a high level of trust and communication between partners, therefore, in case these elements are not properly managed, partnerships can lead to disputes and even legal action (Weber, 2020).

Media Coverage

There are certain legal considerations that can come into play when it comes to media coverage. In Belgium, media outlets are subject to a number of legal requirements and ethical standards when it comes to the accuracy and fairness of their coverage (Schwarz, 2020). Under Belgian law, media outlets are prohibited from publishing or broadcasting false or misleading information that could harm the reputation of an individual or business and if a media outlet is found to have engaged in deceptive or misleading coverage, it may be subject to legal action, including defamation lawsuits brought by individuals or businesses whose reputation has been damaged by the coverage (Mayr, 2022). It is important for media outlets operating in Belgium to adhere to legal and ethical standards when it comes to their coverage, in order to avoid legal consequences and to maintain the trust of their audiences.

Social Media Advertising

“The most important instrument containing general rules on advertising practices in Belgium is the Belgian Economic Law Code (ELC).” (Matthys, 2022). In Belgium, advertisements must be truthful and not misleading to consumers, respect the privacy of individuals and not discriminate against certain groups, comply with rules regarding the use of images and endorsements, not encourage or incite violence or discrimination, and not contain content that is illegal or contrary to public order and morality, comply with specific rules related to certain products or services such as food, drugs, and gambling and comply with the rules of the sector-specific self-regulatory bodies such as the Belgian Advertising Code and the Belgian Self-Regulation Code for the Pharmaceutical Industry. Companies are liable for the content of advertisements and must be able to prove that they have taken all necessary measures to ensure compliance with the rules (Matthys, 2022).

Utilization of SEO

In Belgium, there are no specific laws that regulate SEO practices. However, SEO practices must adhere to the guidelines and best practices set by search engines, such as Google as these guidelines outline what is and is not acceptable in terms of SEO tactics and techniques and may be updated from time to time (Moore, 2021). In addition, SEO practices must comply with general laws and regulations related to advertising, consumer protection, and privacy (Anderson, 2022). This includes the prohibition of deceptive or misleading advertising practices, the requirement to protect the personal data of users, and the obligation to provide accurate and transparent information about products and services. It is important for individuals and businesses engaging in SEO in Belgium to familiarize themselves with these guidelines and to ensure that their practices comply with them.

Acquiring Clients – Contracting

According to Mul (2022), Contract law in Belgium is regulated by the Civil Code, which sets out the general principles and rules governing contracts and their performance. The formation of a contract requires the presence of an offer and an acceptance, as well as an intention to create a legally binding relationship. The contract must also be for a legitimate purpose, and the parties must have the capacity to enter into it. Additionally, the contract must include essential clauses, such as the price, the duration, the method of performance, and the termination. Parties may agree on other additional clauses, which are subject to the general rules of contract law. Finally, contracts must be performed in good faith and the terms stipulated therein must be respected (Mul, 2022).

Appendix D - *cultural aspects (Hofstede)*

The first dimension is the power distance index (PDI), which indicates how power is distributed equally or unequally. It focuses on how society handles social inequalities. The Netherlands received a score of 38, indicating that it ranks low in this dimension. In other words, the Netherlands is an independent country with a hierarchy for convenience. In comparison to Belgium, which scored 65 on the PDI scale, the Netherlands maintains power through a hierarchical structure in which managers monitor employees but rely on their team members. Control is disliked, and the attitudes are informal, direct, and participative communication. On the other hand, as previously stated, Belgium is ranked high, indicating that inequalities are tolerated, and hierarchy is required. They have a formal relationship within the company, and control is expected (Hofstede Insights, 2021).

The second dimension is individualism, which indicates whether a society is individualist, which means that people are only supposed to look after themselves and their families, whereas a collectivist society looks after others in exchange for loyalty. Belgium received a score of 75, indicating that Belgian society is largely individualistic. In the workplace, relationships are contractual, and opinions are permitted but must remain formal and indirect towards dominant groups. The Netherlands, like Belgium, ranks high in this dimension, indicating that people are used to looking after themselves and their families and that the work environment is contract-based (Hofstede Insights, 2021).

The third dimension is masculinity, which means that if a society is ranked high (masculine), it means that the society is driven by competition, accomplishments, and success, whereas if a society is ranked low (feminine), it means that the dominant values in that society are caring for others and quality of life. As a result, a masculine society is defined by wanting to be the best, while a feminine society is defined by enjoying what you do. The Netherlands, ranked 14, is considered feminine, which means that it is important in Dutch society to maintain a life/work balance by including both. Conflicts are frequently resolved through common ground and dialogue. Belgium, on the other hand, has an intermediate score of 54 due to cultural differences between the regions, where the Flemish one is ranked 43, indicating a more feminine society, and the French one is ranked 60, indicating a more masculine society (Hofstede Insights, 2021).

The fourth dimension is the uncertainty avoidance index (UAI), which represents how a society handles future uncertainty: controlling it or avoiding trying to control it. Belgium is ranked very high in this case, at 94, due to their history of being controlled by others. Planning, including structure, rules, and security, is thus favored in Belgium. Such as, the Netherlands, scored 53, indicating that Dutch society prefers to avoid uncertainty (Hofstede Insights, 2021).

The fifth dimension is long-term orientation, which refers to how societies maintain links to their past while facing present and future challenges. Low-scoring societies prefer to maintain customs and traditions, whereas high-scoring societies encourage modernization to

prepare for the future. Belgium and the Netherlands both rank highly in this category (82 for Belgium and 67 for the Netherlands). It implies that both societies are pragmatic and easily adapt to change (Hofstede Insights, 2021).

Indulgence is the sixth and final dimension. It refers to "how far people try to control their desires and impulses" (Hofstede Insights, 2021). Belgium received a score of 57 in this dimension, indicating that they are indulgent, willing to satisfy their impulses and desires with a positive attitude and optimism. The Netherlands received a score of 68, demonstrating how indulgent this country is as well. Both of those countries place a high value on leisure and spending money and time on what they desire (Hofstede Insights, 2021).

Appendix E – CSR

The first model is the Carroll's CSR pyramid. This model is a framework that explains how and why organizations should take social responsibility. The pyramid developed by Archie B. Carroll highlights the four most important types of responsibility of organizations (Toolshero, 2022).

Starting at the bottom of the pyramid you have the economic responsibilities. This part is about the responsibility of producing goods and services that society needs and to make a profit on them. Comparing this to Beex they want to deliver high quality results to their clients which they are happy with, but obviously also want to make a profit on it to keep their business running. Up next is the legal responsibilities. This is about complying with the minimum rules that have been set. An example for this that Beex must follow in Belgium is for instance the GDPR. The third part is the ethical responsibility. This means that organizations embrace activities, standards and practices that haven't necessarily been written down, but are still expected. This can for example be that Belgium is very multilingual so this is something that Beex should be considering. Besides that, another example can also be gender equality. And lastly on top of the pyramid is the philanthropic responsibilities. This includes the voluntary or discretionary activities and practices of a business.

Doing this gives the public the impression that the company wants to give something back to the community. An example for this could be for instance doing donations or giving out gifts (Toolshero, 2022). Another model to look at CSR is the triple bottom line. This model implies that companies commit to focusing as much on social and environmental concerns as they do on profits. The model was found by John Elkington in 1994, with the idea that companies can be managed in a way that they not only make money but also improve people's lives and the well-being of the planet. The triple bottom line stands for 3 p's. Profit, people, and planet (Triple Bottom Line, 2022). The first p, profit in the triple bottom line can mean more than just how much money a company makes. It is important that a company ensures that it earns its income in ethical, fair manners. And also defines how a company develops its strategy or financial operating plan. An example for this is ensuring that Beex is paying the taxes they must pay according to Belgium's rules on a timely basis. And making sure that the company is fostering economic wealth within its community. The second p, people refers to every

individual that is in touch with a company. For this companies would normally prioritize investors or shareholders. But the triple bottom line shifts the focus to individuals that potentially are not financially invested in the company but are still tangentially involved with its operations. For Beex this could for instance be the fact they find personal contact with their clients so important. The last p, planet measures how environmentally responsible a firm has been. This includes for instance the choice between a lower-cost or more environmentally friendly option.



Figure 14. *Triple bottom line. (A Simple Explanation of the Triple Bottom Line | University of Wisconsin, 2022)*



Figure 13. *Carroll's CSR pyramid. (Janse, 2022)*

Appendix F – Strategic choice; country criteria

As the chosen country, Belgium, it is critical to conduct a thorough external and internal market analysis. To do so, a swot analysis of Belgium will be created, following Momin's (2022) research, to present all of the opportunities, strengths, weaknesses, and threats that Beex can encounter by exporting to this country. Adding to this, a PESTLE analysis, the ANSOFF growth matrix and the Porter's generic strategy will be supporting the strategic decision to export Beex to Belgium. Based on our chosen criteria, what exactly makes Belgium the IDEAL country for BEEEX?

Firstly, Belgium is in the European Union, making the export less complicated and less prone to struggle with foreign restrictions and laws. Something that also majorly stood out was the option to stay a Dutch speaking company since Belgium does have a Dutch speaking part, which would make internal communication between the Dutch and Belgian office much easier. Since Belgium is split into the French and Flemish part, basing the new BEEEX office in the Flemish part of the country, possibly Antwerp, would make the most sense. This way both Dutch and English will be understood.

When it comes to the PR industry growth of Belgium, a good future is projected to be ahead with its public relations and communication industries generating up to 2.4 mil USD by the year 2025. This goes hand in hand with the shares of Belgian enterprises using social media, which rose from only 42% in 2014 to 74% in 2021 and projects a thriving, but still upcoming market for BEEEX to export to. This is especially visible when comparing the Belgian shares with e.g., the Norwegian ones of 84% (Statista, 2022a).

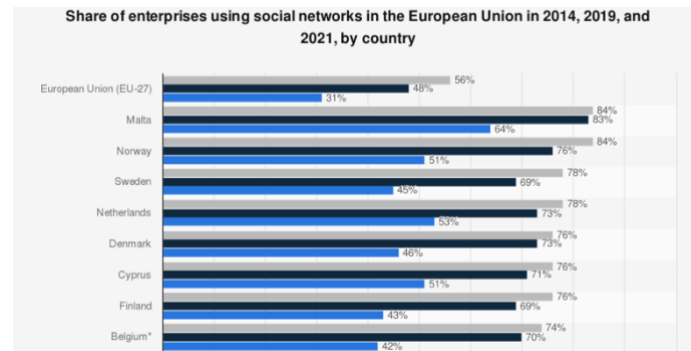


Figure 2. *Share of enterprises using social networks in the EU.* (Statista, 2022a)

Judging the political factors that were part of the criteria, Belgium makes it into the top 25 most politically stable countries in Europe, which makes it great and safe soil for a company to grow (The World Bank, 2021). Still, the various linguistic and cultural identities as well as the accordingly complex federal political structure found in Belgium could create possible future conflicts, which has to be taken into account, especially when choosing the right city for the Belgian BEEEX office (Gupta, 2021).

Given that most Belgian businesses in their industry are quite small and don't employ as many people just like BEEEX, there is room for BEEEX to export its services to the Belgian market instead of being overpowered by big Agencies with 50+ employees (Sortlist, n.d.). Still, this also means lots of similar sized competition is present, such as Antwerp based companies like Nightingale, oona, ONLYHUMANS, Keep It Quiet or The Other Agency. And although that could mean less clients for BEEEX, there is still a big chance that BEEEX won't have a lot of issue with competition. They will require BEEEX to really stand out and offer unique, high quality services to be able to convince clients to choose them over already established Belgian agencies. Due to their all-inclusive service model that works with subscription, they will achieve this. In comparison, most of the other similar PR agencies work project based and require a personal quote. This, combined by the intimate all women team really makes BEEEX stand out from competition.

However, lots of same size companies also show that the market is there and that there is a need to be fulfilled by these smaller boutique agencies. Like for any company, the main goal is to make profit and that can only be achieved if there are clients in the country and region BEEEX will export to. Looking at some possible clients that fit to BEEEX's target group of lifestyle, fashion or food companies with investors, upcoming clothing brands based in Belgium, like A Natural Connection or Valentine Witmeur would fit to BEEEX' portfolio. Other possible clients could be cafes like Butchers Coffee or restaurants like Livelli lasagne. There is definitely space to grow and gain bigger clients like e.g., Ikea, L'Oréal Paris or Levi's.

Appendix G – *Earning model; benefits and threats of subscription models*

To further visualize the five dimensions of a revenue model, the framework seen in Figure 8 can be used. Starting with the WHO, clients, or their investors will be the ones paying BEEEX. This will happen in form of subscription and one time purchases, answering the HOW and they will pay for the activities that the BEEEX employees will be doing, e.g., managing, creating content, or coming up with ideas, as well as the actual content that will be created, as in the content itself, pictures, logos, packaging, know-how and connections. This

shows that the FOR WHAT BEEEX will be paid, consists of both intangible services but also tangible products. WHAT is paid will be the monthly amount of money depending on the chosen subscription, as well as the network that will automatically be extended to the client's network and therefore benefit BEEEX in other way than just money. Lastly, considering the HOW MUCH is paid, BEEEX's pricing will be determined by a set hourly rate, which will have a so-called volume discount, discounting the hourly price when costumers choose the largest subscription.



There is also the option of requesting unsure which type of subscription/package to tailored to the client's needs as stated on their website (Beex, 2022).

The subscription model's primary business benefit is that it allows brands to establish recurring relationships with customers (Johnson, 2022). In research from Johnson, a creative business writer and industry insights blogger (2022), the following are some of the advantages of the subscription model for the clients and the business, reliable recurring revenue, strong client base and increased customer loyalty, easier financial forecasting, increased LTV (Customer lifetime value), and reduced churn, by making their subscription offerings flexible and better customer retention. Furthermore, introducing this new kind of earning model for PR agencies into the Belgium market can therefore become a trendsetting company that attracts clients' attention by offering something new. However, the subscription revenue model also has some threats for instance, as this revenue model has started to gain popularity, many businesses may take the opportunity to develop such a model for their business, therefore, increasing risk of competition (Ludin, 2021). Also, to be able to succeed, certain aspects should be thought of, including an attractive price point, seamless process of becoming a client, and valuable service they are providing (Leonard, 2022).

Appendix H – Strategic choice; internal and external analysis

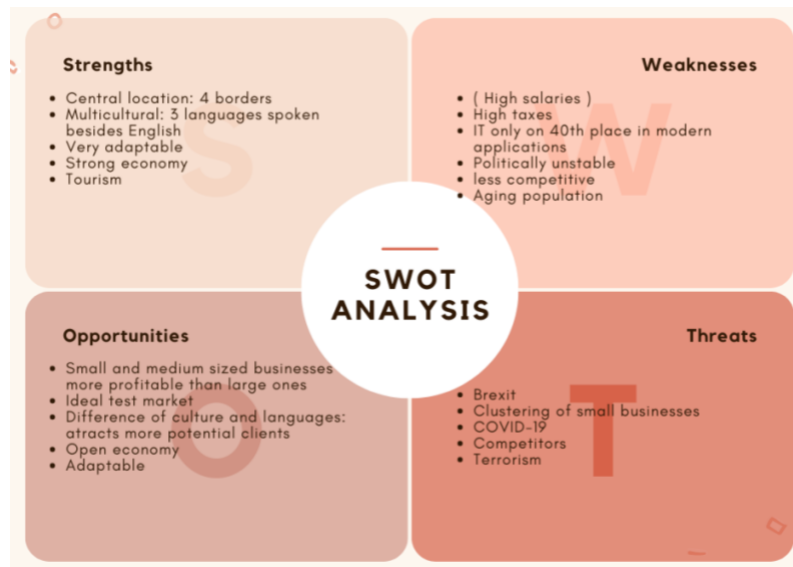


Figure 3. *SWOT analysis of Belgium.*



Figure 4. *PESTLE analysis of Belgium.*

Following a thorough external and internal analysis of the Belgian market, the strategic method chosen to select Belgium as the export country must now be presented. According to Peterdy's (2022) article, the Ansoff Growth matrix, also known as "the Product/Market Expansion Grid," is typically used by management teams to help implement and execute development strategies. The main objective here is to find a suitable country for Beex to export to, as well as to find more clients and connections: brand awareness. The Ansoff matrix has four different boxes that each corresponds to a specific growth strategy (Peterdy, 2022):

- ⇒ Market penetration: The concept of increasing sales of existing products into an existing market.
- ⇒ Market development: Focuses on selling existing products into new markets.
- ⇒ Product development: Focuses on introducing new products to an existing market.
- ⇒ Diversification: The concept of entering a new market with altogether new products.

For BEEEX, a Market Development strategy will be the most logical choice. They will enter a new market, Belgium, but their product/ service isn't entirely new since there are already lots of PR agencies in the market. And although Belgium has a similar culture and characteristics as the Netherlands, which will be further discussed in 3.2, it remains a different location and comes with its own market trends and developments. Therefore, we will be presenting a market development strategy for BEEEX.

Another useful tool to differentiate BEEEX's ideal export strategy is Porters generic strategy, developed by Michael Porter in 1985 and presented in his book, "Competitive Advantage: Creating and Sustaining Superior Performance." (Mind Tools Content Team, n.d.). This framework helps to understand the main generic strategies one can choose to follow. Be it a focus on cost or on standing out and being different and creating something unique, it is all about which focus a company chooses to follow.

Appendix I – Cultural differences; Vann Diagram

With the help of a Vann diagram, we can also see the general cultural differences and similarities between The Netherlands and Belgium in more detail not focusing on only the Hofstede Model. A Venn diagram depicts the logical relationships between two or more sets of items by using overlapping circles or other shapes. They frequently serve to graphically organize things, highlighting how similar and different the items are (*What Is a Venn Diagram*, n.d.).



Figure 6. Cultural differences between Belgium and the Netherlands explained with the Venn diagram (Source: *Netherlands Vs Belgium: The Ultimate Comparison*, 2022)

Appendix J – CSR in Belgium; introduction

Adding to this, employee connections could see improvement due to being motivated to work for a greater good and creating a feeling of pride for the work BEEEX will be doing. This is an aspect that also automatically entails the benefit of employee retention and recruitment, because according to Peters (2019), working for a company with a clear and

committed plan to help the environment, makes 70% of employees more likely to go start working there.

Nevertheless, when creating a CSR strategy some aspects must be thought of, to minimize risks and a negative outcome for the company. This includes choosing values that really do fit to the company and its employees. If we would propose introducing new values, that do not have anything to do with the company and its people, it would feel fake, ingenuine and could create the impression of greenwashing (Kent, 2021). This goes hand in hand with being honest and transparent about what exactly CSR means for BEEEX and what exactly they are doing for this, instead of vaguely mentioning helping the environment e.g., on their website. Another important step is to choose actions towards CSR improvement in issues that truly concern their industry (Kent, 2021). This could mean choosing topics like Women's health or equality to focus on in a CSR strategy first. Lastly, the team, as well as the costumers wishes, and voices should be considered (Kent, 2021). In the end of the day, a CSR strategy that isn't supported by the employees and neither by the clients, makes no sense, leading to less work ethic and less clients since they do not feel like they connect to the company.

Appendix K – Legal implications

As mentioned before in the Benelux The Belgian Office for Intellectual Property is the official body for the registration of trademark. Intellectual property in Belgium can be divided in two main categories: industrial property rights and the rights of literary and artistic property. The industrial property rights relate to creations that play an important economic role in the processes of production and distribution. The literary and artistic property includes copyrights and neighboring rights. There are different ways to protect intellectual property in Belgium. One of them is by patent. This is regulated by the Act of 28 March 1984 on patents. It provides protection in the form of a legal title that allows the proprietor to give the right to a third party, for a certain time and in a particular territory, to make, use or sell his invention without their permission. Another way to protect is by the trademark, which is mainly used to distinguish the source of goods or services and to ensure the identity of the user. The way a trademark can be registered can be found in the registration brand name and logo part. Lastly the intellectual property in Belgium is also protected for designs. This implies protection for all the appearance of a part, or all of a product given by the features. The duration of this protection is five years and may be renewed 4 times (Intellectual Property in Belgium, 2020).

Appendix L – Internal organization in Belgium

Strategy

BEEEX's Antwerp will stay very close to the current strategy to sustain competitive advantage. It will be focusing on the transparent, full-service, monthly, subscriptions, while also offering project-based work, which is the current most common way of business of Belgium PR agencies. This decision is rooted in the success BEEEX had with this business model in The Netherlands, and our team's prognosis of a similar market reaction in Belgium. When researching competitors, no subscription-based PR agencies were found, suggesting that BEEEX could really make their mark and drive the Belgian market to innovation (Sortlist,

n.d.). They will also still be focusing on staying a rather small and intimate all women team. Instead of renting their own big office, the Belgian team will be working from home and from coworking spaces to still be able to hold meetings with clients and employees, while minimizing the initial investment. The decision to still invest in a coworking desks subscription is based on the importance of personal one on one contact with the clients, which is one of BEEEX's main features that also differentiates them from competitors.

The idea is it to start on a small scale, to really get an idea of the market and therefore limit risks as well as financial loss. Still, a full financial plan for switching to their own office with own inventory and everything that comes with this change has also been created to be implemented when the first plan has been successful, and the company decided to put more priority to the Belgian business.

Structure

The Belgian BEEEX branch will consist of two employees in the first year. One will be the general manager and the other will be an intern, assisting the general manager. The actual workforce needed to fulfill all the new Belgian clients' projects will therefore still partly be done by the Dutch team, to be able to really test the waters and minimize costs of salaries for further team members or external freelancers. After a successful first year, employing more team members or hiring additional freelancers can be investigated. The full-time intern will be reporting to the general manager on a bi-weekly basis and the general manager will be doing weekly reports for the CEO in Amsterdam. In this first year, the two employees will be able to work in a co-working space for two days a week, scheduling any client meetings in those times. The rest of the days in the week, they will work from home.

Systems

Just like in the Dutch office, there will be certain activities that the team will have to get done each day, week, and month. Although the focus of the Belgian team will mostly be on finding and signing clients in the first year, they will still have monthly meeting with these clients, monthly mailing, as well as some part in content calendar planning. On a weekly basis they will stay in contact with and update the clients, just like the Dutch team, help with creating content for social media as well as design and manager connections to local Belgian influencers. Project based activities like photoshoots will mostly be done in the Dutch office since the Belgian team is working from home or coworking desks and would have to spend extra money on renting studios and equipment etc. To be able to still do project-based traveling and shoots occasionally, depending on the size of the project, a budget for variable costs is included in the financial plan.

Shared Values

BEEEX's core values of personal attention, personalized work with the clients, being flexible and focusing on quality will stay the same, to keep the companies branding and overall goals in line with the Dutch office. Still, the addition of a CSR strategy will suggest adding some more clear values like sustainability, inclusivity, gender equality & reduced inequalities (which they are indirectly already promoting by being an all women team), climate action or partnerships for these goals (United Nations, n.d.). Something that can also be shifted more focus on is their transparency when it comes to services and pricing. When researching competitors, no other agencies openly disclosed their pricing. This could really be something that BEEEX Belgium can use for e.g., future marketing purposes.

Style

As seen in 3.2 Cultural aspects, the typical Belgian Power distance is higher than the Dutch one, which could possibly lead to differences in the leadership styles that the Belgium employees are used to. With this being said, the participative management style that is being used in the Dutch office can either be adopted or changed to a more traditional, hierarchy based one like a Bureaucratic Leadership (Jaiswal, 2022).

Staff & Skills

The staff of the Belgium BEEEX branch will consist of two employees. One full time general manager and one full time intern. The general manager will be recruited from the Dutch Team directly or through the companies' connections in the country. This role will have to focus on skills like, marketing, social media and overall market research to find and sign clients. The intern, who will be recruited as a marketing or cross media management graduate from local schools like e.g. Karel de Grote Hogeschool (KdG, n.d.), or as someone from the industry that is looking for more work experience, will be assisting the manager with these tasks, focusing on social media and PR.

Appendix M – Place Data Market

Antwerp, Belgium has emerged as a favorable location for export businesses due to the relatively lower office rent costs as compared to other major cities such as Brussels (See figure 24). The information presented on the Statista website (2022) suggests that the average office rent in Antwerp is significantly lower than that of Brussels, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to minimize their operational costs.

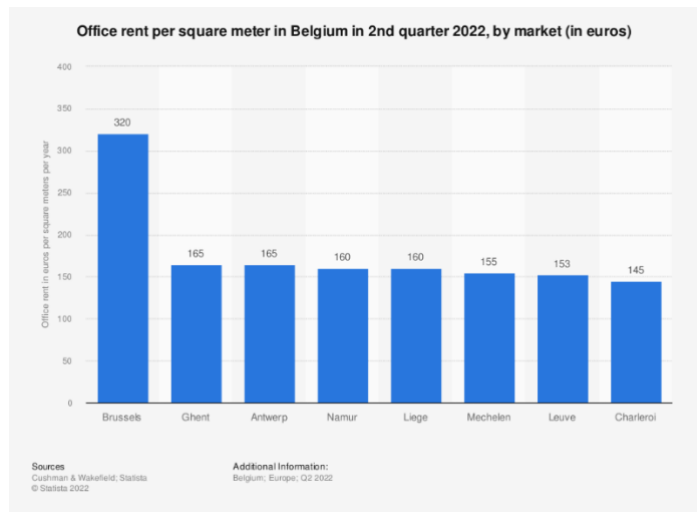


Figure 24. Office rent Belgium (Statista, 2022c)

The rise in PR revenue in Belgium, as indicated by the statistics on Statista (2022), is making the country an attractive destination for export for Beex. The growth in PR revenue is a positive indicator of the strength of the Belgian economy and the increasing demand for marketing and communication services, creating a significant opportunity for Beex to tap into a growing market and increase its presence in the region. The rise in PR revenue is a clear indication that Belgian businesses and organizations are investing more in marketing and communication activities, which is a positive sign for Beex's future prospects in the country. With the increasing demand for communication services, Beex is well positioned to capitalize on this growth.

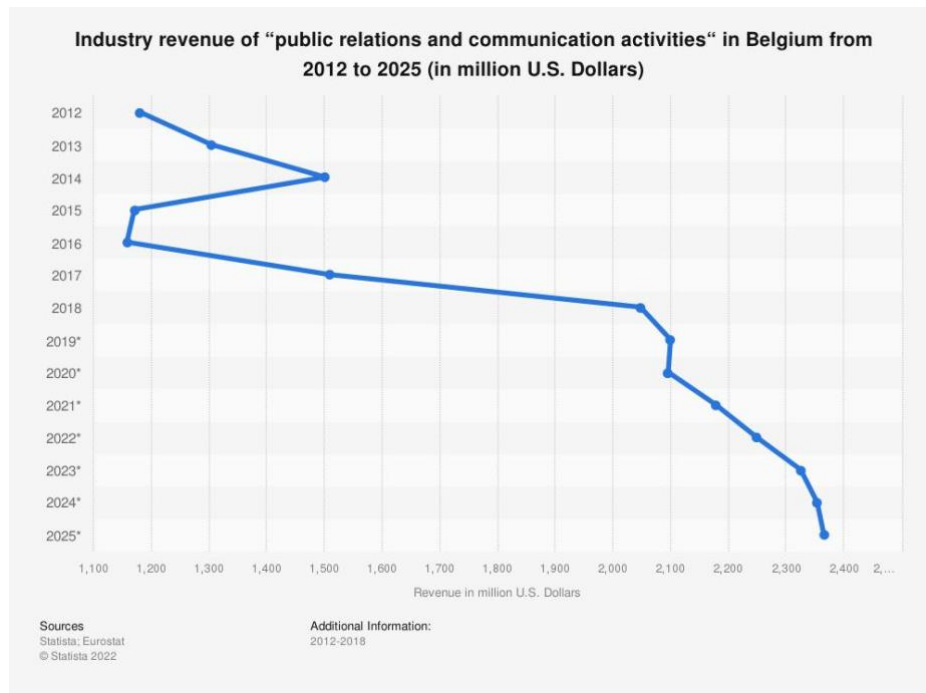


Figure 25. PR Revenue Belgium (Statista, 2022d)